

IN CONTEXT

Finnish nationhood

Although a supporter of Finnish national independence, Sibelius was hostile to the Russia-backed “Red” militia that took over the Helsinki area in 1917, following the Russian Revolution and the seizure of power there by Lenin’s Communist Party. A vicious civil war broke out between the “Reds” and the anti-Communist “White” military forces. Sibelius composed his choral Jäger March to honor the German battalion that fought alongside the “Whites.” Their victory in 1918 led to the foundation of the modern Finnish Republic.



CARL MANNERHEIM, FINNISH “WHITE” MILITARY LEADER IN THE
CIVIL WAR